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Teaching Statement

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Economics education equips students with analytical tools to understand the world around them, evaluate competing explanations, and approach unfamiliar problems systematically. My goal as an educator is not only to teach economic concepts, but also to help students reason independently and apply those concepts beyond the classroom.

My teaching experience began during graduate school and has continued to develop throughout my time at Penn State. It spans undergraduate, M.A., and Ph.D. courses, including Principles of Macroeconomics, Intermediate Macroeconomics, Money and Banking, Urban Economics, graduate Macroeconomics, and a Ph.D. topics course in Firm Dynamics. These experiences have shaped my teaching philosophy around three principles: motivating students through economic intuition and real-world applications, developing independent and critical reasoning, and creating an inclusive and supportive learning environment.

First, I believe effective teaching begins by motivating students' intellectual curiosity and helping them understand why the material matters. I introduce new topics by highlighting the economic question at stake and emphasize intuition before formal derivations. For example, when explaining the relationship between marginal and average values, I use the familiar example of how one student's exam score affects the class average. Such examples help students connect abstract concepts to economic reasoning.

Second, I view developing students' critical reasoning as a central objective of economics education. Rather than immediately providing answers, I guide students through the reasoning needed to approach a problem and encourage them to articulate and defend their own conclusions. Through assignments and classroom discussions, I aim to teach students not only how to solve a particular problem, but also how economists formulate questions, identify mechanisms, and evaluate competing explanations.

Third, I strive to create an inclusive and interactive learning environment that recognizes differences in students' backgrounds, preparation, and comparative strengths. I value open communication and encourage students to ask questions, share their perspectives, and provide feedback on how they are learning. I hold regular office hours and make myself available for individual meetings when students need additional guidance. These interactions help me adapt my explanations and course design to students' needs and reinforce my view that accessibility and individualized feedback are important complements to instruction.

My experience teaching across different levels has also shaped how I design courses. At Penn State, I have taught the M.A. core course in Macroeconomics, developed and taught the Ph.D. course "Firm Dynamics: From Micro Data to Macro Models", and currently teach undergraduate Urban Economics. These courses require substantially different levels of technical depth, exposition, and student engagement. At the undergraduate level, I place greater emphasis on intuition, applications, and connecting economic models to familiar settings; in graduate courses, I increasingly emphasize the link between empirical facts, theoretical models, and frontier research. Student and faculty evaluations have highlighted the organization and clarity of my courses, the connection between theory and empirical applications, and a classroom environment in which students feel comfortable asking questions.

Course development has become an especially important part of my teaching. I designed my Ph.D. course in Firm Dynamics from the ground up, drawing on foundational and frontier research in firm dynamics, innovation, growth, and labor markets. The course moves from empirical facts to canonical models and recent research and incorporates student presentations and research proposals throughout. My objective is not simply to expose students to the literature, but to teach them how to move from an empirical fact or economic question to a researchable idea, identify appropriate data and theoretical frameworks, and critically evaluate existing work. Students have used course projects as starting points for subsequent research papers.

Teaching for me also extends beyond the classroom. I greatly enjoy advising students and helping them develop from consumers of economic research into independent researchers. At Penn State, I have advised undergraduate and Ph.D. students, served on Ph.D. comprehensive-examination committees, supervised undergraduate and graduate research assistants, and advised students on research projects and restricted-data applications. My approach to advising parallels my classroom teaching: rather than providing a ready-made answer, I help students identify the underlying economic question, evaluate alternative approaches, and develop confidence in their own judgment. As students progress, I shift from providing structure toward encouraging greater independence.

Looking forward, I am excited to continue developing as both a teacher and an advisor. My research background prepares me to teach courses in macroeconomics, firm dynamics, economic growth, innovation, and labor markets at both the undergraduate and graduate levels. At the same time, my experience developing new courses has made me enthusiastic about contributing wherever there are curricular needs. I would be happy to teach a broader range of courses according to the needs of the department. Ultimately, my goal is for students to leave my courses with a stronger understanding of economics and greater confidence in their ability to use economic reasoning independently.